which also meant that these languages were given more defined written forms and were, ultimately, able to survive into the present day. The Freising Manuscripts, from the tenth and eleventh centuries, for example, which were written in early Slovenian, became the oldest written texts in any Slavic language in the Latin alphabet.

Twentieth-century historiography, as revised by the Communist authorities after World War II, tried to portray Christianisation primarily as the political subjugation of Slavs by Germans. But while it is true that Slavs – with the possible exceptions of the Poles and the Czechs – lagged behind Western Europe in terms of political organisation and were politically subdued by the Germans, they did manage to survive as distinct ethnic groups until the present day. The fact that they were included in the family of Christian nations (with all the political consequences that followed this) certainly did help to prevent them being wiped out as pagans, which was the fate of some peoples of early medieval Europe who persisted in their pagan beliefs and practices.

By around the thirteenth century therefore, what today we call Eastern Europe was almost fully included in Christendom – the ‘Europe’ of the day. But there was one important distinction within the region: the peoples or ethnic groups of Eastern Europe, who received Christianity from Constantinople, adopted the Greek version of it, together with the Greek script (later developed into Cyrillic) and they accepted cultural and political influence from Byzantium. By contrast, Slovenians, Croats, Slovaks, Hungarians, Czechs and Poles received Christianity largely from the German church (and also, to a much lesser extent, from the Latin lands of modern northern Italy) and, consequently, they have adopted Latin script, Western thought and Western political organisation.

Eastern Europe proper was thus born out of the schism in the Church, the split that also occurred because of the political rivalry between the Byzantines and the Franks over the bodies and souls of the Slavs. However, this was not the same Eastern Europe that we know today; it was certainly not called ‘Eastern Europe’ then. At the head of medieval ‘Eastern Europe’ was Greece which was surrounded by nations that had adopted the rites of Greek Christianity like the Serbs, the Bulgarians and the early Russians. Further west and north, however, there was another ‘Eastern’ Europe which used Western Christian rites. From this time to the present day, these two